

English Grammar for the UPSC Vice Principal CRT: Rules UPSC Actually Tests

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English Grammar for the UPSC Vice Principal CRT

How UPSC tests English in this paper

The English section is quick marks if you know about twelve rule families; it is not a literature test.

The syllabus line is only "Hindi and English language skills" (Advt. 51/2026, Appendix-I). The closest previous paper (VP RT, 11 Dec 2022) has not yet been analysed in this folder, so the table below is the standard objective-English pattern used in recruitment tests, not a confirmed breakdown of the UPSC paper:

Question type	What is really being tested
Spot the error (sentence split into 3 parts + "No error")	Agreement, tense, preposition, article
Fill in the blank	Preposition, article, tense, conjunction pair
Sentence improvement	Idiomatic usage, "No improvement" trap
Active/passive, direct/indirect	Fixed transformation rules
Synonym, antonym, idiom, one-word substitution	Vocabulary
Sentence rearrangement, short passage	Reading logic

With **one-third negative marking** (each wrong answer loses one-third of that question's marks; a blank costs nothing), attempt only the items where you can name the rule. The rules below are the ones that generate the wrong options.

Subject-verb agreement

The verb agrees with the real subject, not with the noun standing nearest to it.

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``mermaid flowchart TD
  A["Find the real subject"] --> B["as well as: first subject"]
  A --> C["neither...nor: nearer subject"]
  A --> D["each, every: singular verb"]
  A --> E["a number of: plural"]
  A --> F["the number of: singular"]
  A --> G["Uncountable nouns: singular"]
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- Words between subject and verb do not change the number: *The **list** of candidates **is** ready.*
- "**as well as**", "**along with**", "**together with**", "**in addition to**", "**no less than**", "**and not**": the verb agrees with the **first** subject. *The Principal, as well as the teachers, **was** present.*
- "**either...or**", "**neither...nor**", "**not only...but also**": the verb agrees with the **nearer** subject. *Neither the Principal nor the teachers **were** informed.*
- "**each**", "**every**", "**either**", "**neither**", "**anyone**", "**everyone**", "**nobody**" take a **singular** verb and a singular pronoun. *Each of the boys **has** done **his** work.*
- "**one of the**" + plural noun + singular verb: *One of the **students** **has** failed.* The clause after "who" agrees with the plural noun: *One of the students **who were** punished has apologised.*
- "**A number of**" = plural verb; "**The number of**" = singular verb. *A number of teachers **are** absent.*
*The number of absentees **is** large.*
- **Collective nouns** (committee, staff, jury, government) are singular when acting as one unit, plural when members act separately.
- **Uncountable nouns are always singular**: furniture, information, advice, luggage, news, scenery, machinery, poetry, evidence, and hair (meaning all the hair on the head). Never "furnitures" or "an advice"; say "a piece of advice". ("Hairs" is correct only for individual strands: *two grey hairs.*)

- **Plural-only nouns:** scissors, trousers, spectacles, premises, thanks, proceeds, alms. *The premises **were** inspected.*
- **Plural in form, singular in meaning:** news, mathematics, physics, economics, politics (as a subject), measles. *Mathematics **is** my subject.*
- **Distances, sums, periods** as one amount take a singular verb: *Ten thousand rupees **is** a big sum. Five kilometres **is** a long walk.*
- **"Many a" + singular noun + singular verb:** *Many a student **has** tried.*

Tenses and sequence of tenses

Time words fix the tense; and a past main clause normally pulls the subordinate clause into the past.

Time marker	Tense required
yesterday, last year, in 2020, ago	Simple past (<i>went</i>)
since, for, already, just, yet, so far, recently	Present perfect (<i>has gone</i>)
by the time X happens, by 2027	Future perfect (<i>will have gone</i>)
when X came (another past action already over)	Past perfect (<i>had gone</i>)
while, at that moment	Continuous (<i>was going</i>)

Key rules:

- **Never use the present perfect with a definite past time word.** *He has joined in 2019* is wrong; *He joined in 2019* or *He has been here since 2019* is right.

- **Present perfect is never used with "ago" or "yesterday".**
- **Sequence of tenses:** a past tense in the main clause takes a past tense in the subordinate clause. *He said that he **was** tired.* Exceptions: **universal truths, habitual facts, and "than" comparisons** keep their own tense. *The teacher said that the earth **revolves** round the sun.*
- **Two past actions:** the earlier one takes **past perfect**. *The train **had left** before we **reached** the station.*
- **"Had better", "would rather", "must", "should"** are followed by the **bare infinitive**: *You **had better leave** now.*
- After **"if", "when", "unless", "till", "as soon as", "before"** in a future sense, use the **simple present**, not "will". *I **will** call you when he **comes**.*
- **Stative verbs** (know, believe, own, belong, understand, like, seem) are not normally used in continuous forms. *I **am knowing** him* is wrong.

Articles and determiners

"A/an" depends on the first sound, not the first letter; **"the"** marks a known or unique thing.

- **"an"** before a vowel **sound**: an hour, an honest man, an MLA, an M.A., an FIR, an X-ray. **"a"** before a consonant **sound**: a university, a union, a European, a one-rupee coin, a useful book.
- **"The"** is used with: superlatives (**the** best), ordinals (**the** first), unique objects (**the** sun), rivers, seas,

oceans, mountain ranges, deserts, plural country names (**the** Netherlands, **the** USA), holy books (**the** Gita), newspapers (**the** Hindu), musical instruments (plays **the** sitar), adjectives used as nouns for a whole class (**the** rich, **the** poor), and nationalities as a group (**the** French).

- **No article** before: names of languages, subjects, meals, diseases, abstract nouns in a general sense, and the words school, college, church, hospital, bed, prison when used for their **purpose** (*go to school*; but *go to the school to meet the Principal*).
- "**Few / little**" = hardly any (negative). "**A few / a little**" = some (positive). "**The few / the little**" = all that there is.
- "**Each**" is used for two or more; "**every**" for three or more. "**Either/neither**" are for **two** only; for more than two use "**any / none**".
- "**Fewer**" with countable nouns, "**less**" with uncountable: *fewer students, less time*.
- "**Elder / eldest**" only for family members and only attributively (*my elder brother*); "**older / oldest**" for everything, and only "older" takes "than". *He is elder than me* is wrong.

Prepositions and conjunctions

Most preposition errors come from a short list of fixed pairs.

Correct usage	Common wrong form
senior / junior / superior / inferior / prior / preferable to	senior than
different from ; similar to	different than
responsible to a person for a thing	responsible for a person
agree with a person, to a proposal	agree to a person
consist of ; comprise (no "of")	comprise of
die of a disease, from a wound, for a cause	die with
married to ; angry with a person, at a thing	married with
discuss, order, attack, resemble, enter, reach + object (no preposition)	discuss about , enter into a room
since + point of time; for + period	since two hours
between two; among more than two	between the three
in time (before the deadline); on time (exactly)	—
beside = next to; besides = in addition to	—

Correlative conjunctions must be in pairs and placed in parallel positions: **either...or, neither...nor, not only...but also, both...and, hardly/scarcely...when, no sooner...than, so...that, such...that, as...as, so...as (negative), lest...should.**

- *No sooner had the bell rung **than** the students left.*
Never "no sooner...then".

- *Hardly had he entered **when** the phone rang.* Never "hardly...than".
- "**Unless**" already contains "not": *Unless you work hard, you will fail.* Never "unless you do not".
- "**Lest**" takes "**should**": *Work hard lest you **should** fail.*
- Do not use "**although...but**" or "**because...so**" together in one sentence.

Pronouns, adjectives and adverbs

The case of a pronoun depends on its job in the clause; comparison words follow fixed patterns.

- After "**than**" and "**as**", use the subject form when a verb is understood: *He is taller than I (am).* Exam keys follow this formal rule.
- After **prepositions and transitive verbs**, use the object form: *between you and **me**; let **him** and **me** go.*
- Order of persons: **231 for normal, 123 for admitting a fault.** *You, he and I will go. I, you and he are to blame.*
- "**Who**" is subject, "**whom**" is object: *the teacher **whom** we met; the teacher **who** met us.*
- "**Whose**" can be used for persons and things; "**which**" never for persons.
- "**One...one's**": *One should do **one's** duty,* not "his duty".
- "**Each other**" for two, "**one another**" for more than two.

- A **relative pronoun** must stand next to its antecedent.
- **Double comparatives/superlatives** are wrong: *more better, most tallest.*
- **"Than"** after comparatives; but **"prefer...to"**: *I prefer tea **to** coffee.*
- Comparing one item with the rest of its group needs **"any other"**: *Delhi is bigger than **any other** city in India.*
- Adjectives that have no degrees: **unique, perfect, complete, round, universal, full, empty.** "More unique" is wrong.
- Verbs of sense (look, smell, taste, feel, sound) take an **adjective**, not an adverb: *The soup tastes **good**.*
- **"Hardly / scarcely"** mean almost not; **"hard"** is the adverb of effort. *He works **hard**; he **hardly** works.*
- **"Very"** modifies adjectives and present participles; **"much"** modifies comparatives and past participles: *very interesting, much surprised, much better.* But past participles that have become ordinary adjectives take "very": *very tired, very pleased.* In modern usage *very interested* is also standard, so do not mark it wrong unless every other option is clearly correct.

Active and passive voice

Keep the tense, change the object into the subject, and use the correct form of "be" + past participle.

Active	Passive
writes	is written
is writing	is being written
wrote	was written
was writing	was being written
has written	has been written
had written	had been written
will write	will be written
can / must write	can / must be written

Rules examiners use for wrong options:

- Only **transitive** verbs have a passive. *He sleeps* has no passive.
- **Perfect continuous and future continuous** tenses are not normally changed to passive.
- Imperatives: *Open the door.* → *Let the door **be opened**.* / *You are requested to open the door* (for requests).
- Questions keep the question form: *Who wrote this?* → ***By whom** was this written?*
- Verbs with two objects can take either as the passive subject: *The Principal gave him a prize.* → *He was given a prize / A prize was given to him.*
- Some verbs take prepositions other than "by": *known **to**, surprised **at**, pleased **with**, interested **in**, filled **with**.*
- Modal passives: *The form must be filled in* (phrasal verbs keep their particle).

Direct and indirect speech

Shift the tense one step back, change the pronouns to the reporter's view, and replace "here-and-now" words.

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`mermaid flowchart TD
  A["Direct speech sentence type"] --> B["Statement: said that"]
  A --> C["Yes/no question: asked whether"]
  A --> D["Wh-question: asked + wh-word"]
  A --> E["Command: told to + infinitive"]
  A --> F["Exclamation: exclaimed that"]
  A --> G["Let us: suggested that"]`
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Direct	Indirect
present simple	past simple
present continuous	past continuous
present perfect	past perfect
past simple	past perfect
will / shall / can / may	would / should / could / might
must	had to (or must for permanent rules)

Word changes: **now** → **then**; **today** → **that day**; **yesterday** → **the previous day / the day before**; **tomorrow** → **the next day**; **ago** → **before**; **here** → **there**; **this** → **that**; **these** → **those**; **come** → **go** (only where the sense requires it); **last night** → **the previous night**.

- No tense change if the reporting verb is in the **present or future**, or if the reported speech is a **universal truth**.
- **Questions**: "said to" becomes **asked**; the sentence becomes a statement in word order (no "did", no

question mark). Yes/no questions take **"if / whether"**; wh-questions keep the wh-word. *She said to me, "Where do you live?" → She asked me where I lived.*

- **Commands and requests:** "said to" becomes **ordered, told, requested, advised**, followed by **"to" + infinitive**; negative commands use **"not to"**.
*"Don't talk," the teacher said to the boys → The teacher told the boys **not to talk**.*
- **Exclamations:** use *exclaimed with joy/sorrow that*.
Wishes: *wished that*. **"Let us"** proposals: *suggested / proposed that we should*.

Conditionals, modals and question tags

There are three conditional patterns, and the tag always reverses the sign of the main clause.

Type	If-clause	Main clause	Meaning
1	simple present	will + verb	real / likely
2	simple past (were)	would + verb	unreal present
3	past perfect	would have + past participle	unreal past

- Formal exams expect **"If I were"** for all persons in Type 2, not "If I was".
- Never put **"will"** or **"would"** in the if-clause: *If it will rain* is wrong.
- **Inversion** can replace "if": *Had I known, I would have come*.

Modals: "**can**" = ability/permission; "**may**" = possibility/formal permission; "**must**" = obligation; "**should / ought to**" = duty; "**used to**" = past habit now stopped; "**need not**" + bare infinitive = no necessity; "**dare not**" + bare infinitive. The past of "must" in reported speech is "**had to**".

Question tags:

- Positive statement → **negative tag**; negative statement → **positive tag**. Use the **same auxiliary** and a **pronoun**. *The teachers are here, **aren't they**?*
- "I am" → "aren't I". "Let us" → "shall we".
Imperatives → "will you / won't you". "Let him go" → "will you".
- Words like **hardly, seldom, never, nobody, little, few** make the statement negative, so the tag is positive: *He seldom comes late, **does he**?*
- "**Everybody, nobody, someone**" take "**they**" in the tag: *Everyone passed, **didn't they**?*

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`mermaid flowchart TD
  A["Look at the statement"] --> B["Positive: negative tag"]
  A --> C["Negative: positive tag"]
  A --> D["hardly, seldom, never: positive tag"]
  A --> E["I am: aren't I"]
  A --> F["Let us: shall we"]
  A --> G["Imperative: will you"]`
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Vocabulary: idioms, one-word substitutions and spelling

Learn the high-frequency list; these items are pure recall.

High-frequency idioms in competitive-exam English:

Idiom	Meaning
take with a pinch of salt	accept with doubt
a red-letter day	an important, memorable day
at the eleventh hour	at the last moment
beat about the bush	avoid the main point
a white elephant	a costly but useless possession
in the same boat	in the same difficulty
hit the nail on the head	say exactly the right thing
once in a blue moon	very rarely
turn a deaf ear	refuse to listen
a bolt from the blue	a sudden shock
throw cold water on	discourage
burn the midnight oil	study late at night
call a spade a spade	speak plainly
by leaps and bounds	very rapidly
a hard nut to crack	a difficult problem or person

One-word substitutions that suit an education paper:
pedagogue (a teacher), **pedagogy** (the science of teaching), **curriculum** (course of study), **alumnus / alumni** (former student / students), **philanthropist** (lover of mankind), **misanthrope** (hater of mankind), **omniscient** (all-knowing), **omnipotent** (all-powerful), **ambidextrous** (able to use both hands), **illegible** (cannot be read), **inaudible** (cannot be heard), **truant** (child who stays away from school without leave), **autobiography** (life story written by oneself),

anonymous (unknown name), **posthumous** (after death), **unanimous** (all agreeing), **veteran** (long experienced), **novice** (beginner), **optimist / pessimist**, **plagiarism** (copying another's work as one's own).

Commonly tested spellings: **accommodate**, **committee**, **millennium**, **occurrence**, **separate**, **privilege**, **liaison**, **maintenance**, **harass**, **embarrass**, **recommend**, **questionnaire**, **supersede**, **pronunciation**, **definitely**, **grammar**, **bureaucracy**, **exaggerate**, **conscientious**, **guarantee**.

Sentence rearrangement and comprehension technique

Find the opener and the link words; most jumbles have one obvious first sentence and one obvious last sentence.

- The first sentence introduces a noun by its full name; later sentences use **pronouns (it, they, this)**, **articles ("the" scheme)** and **connectors (however, therefore, also, thus, finally)**.
- Pair sentences that share a noun. Check every option code against two sure links rather than reading all four orders.
- In comprehension, read the questions first, then the passage. Answers must come **only from the passage**, even if your own knowledge differs.
- Vocabulary-in-context questions: substitute each option in the sentence and keep the one that preserves the meaning.

Common traps

- **Nearest noun agreement:** *The quality of the answers **were** poor* is wrong; the subject is "quality".
- **"The number of" with a plural verb:** wrong. "A number of" is plural; "the number of" is singular.
- **Present perfect + past time word:** *has joined in 2019* is wrong.
- **"Senior than", "different than", "comprise of", "discuss about", "enter into the room":** all wrong in formal exams.
- **"No sooner...then" and "hardly...than":** wrong pairs. Correct: no sooner...than; hardly...when.
- **"Unless...not" and "lest...will":** wrong. Unless is already negative; lest takes should.
- **"If I was" and "if...will":** formal keys want "if I were" and a present tense after "if".
- **"More better", "most unique":** double comparison and absolute adjective.
- **"Elder than":** "elder" never takes "than"; use "older than".
- **Indirect speech with "yesterday" or "did":** the reported question must lose "did" and change "yesterday" to "the previous day".
- **Imperative narration without "to":** "told the boys not talk" is wrong; it is "not to talk".
- **"No error" / "No improvement"** is a real option and is sometimes the key. Choose it only if you cannot name a rule that is broken.

- **Tag with "Let us":** it is "shall we", never "will we" or "don't we".
- **Each other / one another, between / among, few / a few, less / fewer:** the pairs are tested as swaps.
- **Uncountable nouns in the plural:** "furnitures, informations, advices, sceneries, luggages" are always wrong ("hairs" is right only for individual strands).

Remember for the exam

1. Verb agrees with the real subject; **as well as / along with** take the first subject, **either...or / neither...nor** take the nearer subject.
2. **Each, every, everyone, nobody, many a, one of the** take a **singular** verb.
3. **A number of** = plural; **the number of** = singular.
4. **Furniture, information, advice, news, luggage, hair** are singular; **scissors, trousers, premises** are plural.
5. Present perfect never goes with **yesterday, ago, in 2019**.
6. Two past actions: the earlier takes **past perfect**.
7. After **if / when / unless / as soon as** for the future, use **simple present**.
8. **An** before a vowel sound: an hour, an MLA, an honest man; **a** before a consonant sound: a university, a one-rupee note, a European.
9. **Senior, junior, superior, inferior, prior, preferable** take **to**; different takes **from**.

10. **No sooner...than; hardly / scarcely...when; lest... should; unless** (never with "not").
11. Type 2 conditional: **If I were..., I would...;** never "will" in the if-clause.
12. Passive = same tense, **be + past participle;** questions become **By whom...?;** imperatives become **Let...be + past participle.**
13. Indirect speech: one tense back; **yesterday → the previous day, tomorrow → the next day, ago → before, now → then;** questions lose "did" and take **if / whether** or the wh-word.
14. Question tags reverse the sign: **I am → aren't I; Let us → shall we; imperatives → will you;** hardly / seldom / never make the tag positive.
15. **Elder / eldest** only for family and never with "than"; **older than** for all.

Quick facts

- With 'as well as', 'along with', 'together with' and 'in addition to', the verb agrees with the **FIRST** subject; with 'either...or' and 'neither...nor' it agrees with the **NEARER** subject.
- 'Each', 'every', 'everyone', 'nobody', 'many a' and 'one of the + plural noun' all take a singular verb.
- 'A number of' takes a plural verb; 'the number of' takes a singular verb.
- Furniture, information, advice, news, luggage, scenery, hair (the mass on the head) and evidence are uncountable and singular;

scissors, trousers, spectacles and premises are always plural.

- Present perfect (has done) is never used with a definite past time word such as yesterday, ago, last year or in 2019.
- Of two past actions, the earlier one takes the past perfect: 'The train had left before we reached.'
- After 'if', 'when', 'unless', 'as soon as' and 'before' in a future sense, use the simple present, never 'will'.
- 'An' goes before a vowel SOUND (an hour, an MLA, an honest man); 'a' before a consonant sound (a university, a European, a one-rupee coin).
- Senior, junior, superior, inferior, prior and preferable take 'to'; 'different' takes 'from'; 'responsible' takes 'to' a person and 'for' a thing.
- Fixed pairs: no sooner...than; hardly/scarcely...when; lest...should; 'unless' is already negative so never add 'not'.
- Type 2 conditional uses 'If I were..., I would...'; Type 3 uses 'If I had..., I would have...'; 'will' never appears in the if-clause.
- Passive keeps the tense and uses be + past participle; a 'Who...?' question becomes 'By whom...?'; an imperative becomes 'Let ... be + past participle'.

- In indirect speech, tenses go one step back and now→then, today→that day, yesterday→the previous day, tomorrow→the next day, ago→before, here→there.
- Question tags reverse the sign of the statement: 'I am' → 'aren't I'; 'Let us' → 'shall we'; imperatives → 'will you'; hardly/seldom/never make the statement negative so the tag is positive.
- 'Elder/eldest' are used only for family members and never with 'than'; use 'older than'. 'Fewer' goes with countable nouns and 'less' with uncountable nouns.